

NEW NATIONS

On 12 August 1947, British lawyer Cyril Radcliffe sent his recommendations for the boundaries that would become India and Pakistan to the Viceroy Lord Mountbatten. Everything had to be partitioned, including the railways, and India suddenly found itself in possession of a lopsided railway system as lines, workshops, rolling stock, and even manpower were divided.



Insignia of the pre-Independence North Western Railway

Cyril Radcliffe was appointed the chairman of the two Boundary Commissions, which had been hurriedly created in July 1947 and would decide on the parts of Punjab and Bengal that would go to India and Pakistan. He and the representatives of the two main political parties, the Muslim League and the Congress, had 36 days to decide this. In June, a Partition Council had already started dividing the assets between the two new countries, from railway lines and ships to chairs and typewriters. The decision became public on 17 August.

Though expected, the ultimate division was abrupt. It left people stranded on either side of the border and administrators with the complicated job of dividing a country's assets. Journalist Ajit